

Letter of Commitment

The affidavit was prepared at the request of Dmitry Lagovsky

Dear Ladies and Gentlemen,

My name is Ilya Yashin. I am a Russian politician representing the democratic opposition to the regime of Vladimir Putin. For many years, I have conducted campaigns in Russia in defense of human rights, organized major demonstrations against dictatorship and police brutality, and participated in elections as an independent candidate.

My story has been covered by numerous American and international media outlets, including Time, The New Yorker, The Guardian, and The Associated Press.

True and accurate copies or links to the relevant articles are attached hereto as:

- Exhibit A: [A Message to the World From Inside a Russian Prison], Time (<https://time.com/6254450/ilya-yashin-a-message-to-the-world-from-inside-a-russian-prison/>)
- Exhibit B: [The Russian Prisoner Who Didn't Want to Be Freed], The New Yorker (<https://www.newyorker.com/news/the-lede/the-russian-prisoner-who-didnt-want-to-be-freed>)
- Exhibit C: [Russian opposition figure Ilya Yashin jailed for denouncing Ukraine war], The Guardian (<https://www.theguardian.com/world/2022/dec/09/russian-opposition-figure-ilya-yashin-jailed-for-denouncing-ukraine-war>)
- Exhibit D: [For freed Russian opposition activist Ilya Yashin, resuming work against Putin is his priority], The Associated Press (<https://apnews.com/article/russia-yashin-prisoner-swap-putin-crackdown-ukraine-a74efa54bc6d033b57ee4dd10d1227b6>)

My closest associates, Alexei Navalny and Boris Nemtsov, were killed by the Putin regime. I myself spent more than two years in prison for publicly criticizing the military invasion of Ukraine by Russian troops. I am currently in political exile in the Federal Republic of Germany, following a prisoner exchange in August 2024, in which Russian political prisoners were traded for Putin's agents.

As a person who was criminally prosecuted in Russia on politically motivated charges, I would like to draw your attention to the following:

1. The current state policy of the Russian authorities is clearly aimed at suppressing political dissent and drastically restricting human rights, as guaranteed by the Constitution of the Russian Federation and the Universal Declaration of Human Rights of the United Nations.

2. Criticism of Vladimir Putin and other government officials, anti-war statements, participation in peaceful protests, and other forms of civil opposition are effectively criminalized and equated with extremist or even terrorist activities.

3. Following the start of the war, the Russian parliament, controlled by Putin, adopted extensive legislative amendments enabling the prosecution of citizens for expressing anti-war or opposition views. These include, in particular, the following articles of the Russian Criminal Code:

- Article 280.3: "Discrediting the Armed Forces";
- Article 207.3: "Dissemination of false information about the Armed Forces";
- Article 330.1: "Violation of the obligations of a foreign agent";
- Article 280: "Extremist activity";
- Article 284.1: "Participation in the activities of an undesirable organization."
- Article 205.2: "Criminal liability for public calls to terrorist activity, public justification of terrorism, or propaganda of terrorism."

4. In practice, the Russian legal system regularly uses charges such as "treason" and "terrorism" as instruments of political repression.

– Exhibit E: [Заявление Amnesty International о злоупотреблении антитеррористическим законодательством в России], Amnesty International (<https://www.amnesty.org/ru/latest/news/2024/02/zayavlenie-amnesty-international-o-zloupotreblenii-antiterroristicheskim-zakonodatelstvom-v-rossii/>)

– Exhibit F: [Strategy of blatant abuse of counter-terrorism and extremism laws to destroy Russian civil society must end: UN experts], UN (<https://www.ohchr.org/en/press-releases/2026/04/strategy-blatant-abuse-counter-terrorism-and-extremism-laws-destroy-russian>)

5. Within Russia's law enforcement system, a large-scale "political police" apparatus has been effectively established. Its operations are comparable to the KGB in the Soviet Union and the Stasi in East Germany. This apparatus includes, in particular, the Center for Countering Extremism of the Ministry of Internal Affairs and the Directorate for the Protection of the Constitutional Order of the FSB. Their officers carry out extensive surveillance of opposition activity, fabricate cases against dissidents, and provide operational support for criminal prosecutions against political figures, civil activists, human rights defenders, and independent journalists.

6. According to the estimates of the human rights organization "Memorial" (recipient of the Nobel Peace Prize in 2022), as of February 2024, no fewer than 1620 individuals were being held in Russian prisons for political reasons. This number continues to grow.

Based on my experience, a Russian opposition politician who has repeatedly faced criminal prosecution for criticizing the authorities, hereby state that the return to Russia poses a serious threat to safety of Dmitry Lagovsky.

For a person in Mr. Lagovsky's position, **any detention in a Russian pre-trial detention center (SIZO) carries real, lethal threats** due to the following systemic factors directly tied to Russia's ongoing war:

- **Legalized Recruitment of Detainees:** The Russian Federation has adopted and actively enforces normative acts that explicitly allow for the recruitment of individuals held in pre-trial detention into the fighting army before any verdict or sentencing is reached.
- **Widespread Coercion:** There is a well-documented, systemic practice of coercing detainees and prisoners into signing military contracts with the Ministry of Defense.
- **Use of Torture and Extortion:** To force compliance, detainees are routinely subjected to physical torture, severe psychological pressure, and explicit threats of having new, more severe criminal charges fabricated against them.
- **Specific Vulnerability Due to Military Specialty:** In Mr. Lagovsky's case, these threats are exceptionally high. Because he previously served in the Russian military and possesses a highly valuable military specialty (communications/signalman), he is a prime target. I am informed that military enlistment officers have already targeted him, and he has received explicit propositions offering the closure of his criminal case in exchange for signing a military contract. If placed in a SIZO, he will be entirely at the mercy of this recruitment apparatus.
- **Extreme Risk Due to Ukrainian Origin:** Crucially, Mr. Lagovsky was born in Ukraine. This fact drastically amplifies the danger he faces. If he refuses to sign a contract to fight against his country of birth, he is highly likely to be subjected to brutal discriminatory violence by prison authorities and faces a severe risk of having his charges escalated to High Treason (Article 275) simply for his refusal.

The fact that his extradition process has progressed, while his application for political asylum is pending and a previous complaint to the European Court of Human Rights was not accepted for consideration, places him in a highly precarious legal position.

However, the reality on the ground in Russia remains absolute: the Russian judicial system is not independent, and pre-trial detention centers currently function as forced recruitment pipelines for the military. Accordingly, any form of imprisonment in Russia—even pre-trial detention in a SIZO—is accompanied by completely unacceptable risks to Dmitry Lagovsky's life, physical integrity, and fundamental human rights.

Respectfully,

Ilya Yashin

Berlin, Germany

21.05.2026

A handwritten signature in black ink, consisting of a large 'S' followed by a vertical line and a stylized 'M' or 'W' shape.